

Lesson 7: The Importance of Learning Styles

Danni Varlan

In 2000, I was the program director for a leadership program and Pat invited us to come over and do a learning styles assessment with her players. We were very excited about that, as you can imagine, and were very surprised to find out what everybody's learning style was, as well as Pat.

But the fun part about it was as we did it, she learned some skills that were going to give her an opportunity for communicating better with several of her players. One in particular was just very kind, very nice, loved people, but wanted everybody to be happy. So sometimes that got in the way of a perfect shot and she would stop and pass it off to someone. So, and you know, Pat just wasn't crazy about that. So this was giving her an opportunity to learn how she could more effectively communicate with this player.

On the other hand, she had another player that was a great point guard and she was skilled and was very comfortable making decisions on the fly. In fact, at the end of every game, she would write a three-page legal pad and give Pat her assessment of that game.

Now with her staff, she also found out some very interesting information. You know, sometimes there would be a good cop, bad cop scenario with the team and it became very clear who was going to play what role when they did learning styles. But it also became clear in terms of how comfortable they were with certain subjects with their teams.

So, learning styles became a part of Pat's everyday involvement with her team and actually in her life. She was very interested in how people wanted to communicate and how to best communicate with them.